of cross-over of political interests between the two parties[44] but also shows that the generals remain determined to ensure they retain control of Myanmar's wealth. As discussed above, Shwe Mann represented the faction in the USDP that, expecting to lose badly in 2015, was seeking an accommodation with the NLD.

Growing tensions with the USDP have seen a return to some degree of direct repression. For example, in September 2014 the journalist Par Gyi, who was closely associated with the NLD, was shot while in police custody and subsequently buried in a field. The Myanmar authorities claim he was trying to escape. When his body was exhumed it showed clear 'signs of abuse'.[45]

This shift in NLD–USDP relations matters. One interpretation is that the generals are now prepared to gamble on losing international goodwill by declaring a coup. Equally they may attempt to change the constitution (again) to retain economic power regardless of electoral results. In either case, it is hard to see what the NLD can do in response. This indicates that several key weaknesses in the NLD's strategy remain in place. Despite this, the size of the NLD victory in 2015 may give them sufficient power to deter any attempt by the generals to seize power, but this still leaves the question as to whether the NLD is able to wrest economic power from the military.

First, while the NLD is electorally popular in the ethnically Burman regions, it is not a mass party. It relies, for its connection with the bulk of the population, on its (sometimes uncomfortable) alliance with the Buddhist monks. Second, it remains very dependent on Aung San Suu Kyi for much of its popular recognition. This relatively weak basis for political operations means that the well-organised Buddhist groups have considerable influence over the NLD's practical politics—especially in relation to non-Burman ethnic groups. Thus to understand the final strand in contemporary Myanmar politics, we must turn to look at the Buddhist confessional groups that have become so important since 2008.

The role of Buddhism since 2007

After independence, Buddhism was briefly seen as setting a moral structure for the new state rather than as a marker of who really belonged in the new country. However, under the military the conflation of loyal citizenship with being ethnically Burman and religiously Buddhist was made. This became